STEELE & CO. — LAUNCH CHECKLIST

Everything you need to do *to ship.*

The app is built. The website is built. The athlete bios, the workout logger, the coach dashboard — all working. What's left is the business plumbing: a legal entity, a bank account, a Stripe account, an email domain, and a few pricing decisions. This document walks you through every step.

Read it once end-to-end so you see the full path. Then start at Phase 1. Each task has a recommended option, the alternatives, and the reasoning behind the recommendation. If you have a strong preference for an alternative, take it — the recommendations are starting points, not mandates.

HOW TO READ THIS

Tasks are grouped into six phases. Phases 1 and 2 happen in parallel. Phase 3 needs Phase 1 done first. Phases 4 and 5 are decisions you can make anytime. Phase 6 is ongoing, after launch.

Anywhere you see
SEND TO VAN
, that's a thing the developer needs from you to wire up the system. Send via text or email — doesn't need to be formal.

PHASE I

Legal & financial foundation

Form the company, get a tax ID, open a bank account. These three steps unlock everything else — Stripe needs them, the IRS needs them, the bank needs them. Start here even if you're unsure about the rest.

ESTIMATED: 1–3 WEEKS

PHASE I · STEP 1

Form an LLC

A formal business entity. Without one you're a sole proprietor by default, which works but gives you no liability protection and looks less credible to payment processors and clients.

> RECOMMENDED
>
> **Single-member LLC, filed in your home state.** Cheap (around $100–200), filed online with the Secretary of State, gives you personal-asset protection if a client ever sues, and Stripe treats it as a business with no extra friction.

STEP BY STEP

1. Pick a legal name. *Recommendation:* "Steele & Co. LLC" or "William Steele Coaching LLC". Use your state's Secretary-of-State website to search for name availability before filing.
2. Visit your state's Secretary of State website. Search for "register an LLC". Most states have an online filing portal.
3. Fill out the "Articles of Organization" form. You'll need: legal name, your name + home address (or a registered-agent service's address — see Alternative below), purpose of business ("coaching services" is fine), member name (you).
4. Pay the filing fee with a credit card. Submit.
5. Wait for approval. Usually 1–3 weeks; many states offer a same-day expedited filing for an extra ~$50–100 if you're in a hurry.
6. Save the Articles of Organization PDF you receive. **Send to Van.** The bank and Stripe will both ask for it.

> ALTERNATIVES
>
> **Sole proprietor (no entity).** Free, no paperwork. Stripe accepts it. But your personal assets aren't protected from business liability, and bank-account / business-credit options are limited. *Not recommended unless cost is critical.*
>
> **Registered-agent service.** If you don't want your home address on public state filings, pay ~$50–100/year for a registered-agent service (e.g., Northwest Registered Agent, ZenBusiness). Recommended if privacy matters.

TIME 1–3 weeks (mostly waiting) COST $100–200 + optional ~$50/yr agent

PHASE I · STEP 2

Get an EIN

Employer Identification Number. The IRS's tax ID for businesses. Stripe and the bank both require it. Free, takes 30 minutes, instant approval.

> RECOMMENDED
>
> Apply directly through **irs.gov**. Don't pay any third-party service. EIN applications are free; sites that charge $200+ are scams.

STEP BY STEP

1. Wait until your LLC is approved (you'll need the LLC's legal name on the EIN form).
2. Go to `irs.gov/businesses/small-businesses-self-employed/apply-for-an-employer-identification-number-ein-online`
3. Click "Apply Online Now". Note: only available Mon–Fri, 7am–10pm Eastern.
4. On the "Identify" screen, select **Limited Liability Company (LLC)**.
5. Fill in: your LLC's legal name, state of formation, your name + SSN as the "responsible party", business address, primary activity ("coaching/training services").
6. Submit. The EIN appears on the screen **immediately** — do NOT close the tab without saving the confirmation letter (PDF download).
7. **Send to Van.** The EIN itself (a 9-digit number) and the PDF confirmation letter.

Don't pay anyone for an EIN. Search results often show services like "EIN Filing Service" charging $200+. They're submitting the same free IRS form on your behalf. The official site is `irs.gov` — nowhere else.

TIME 30 minutes COST Free

PHASE I · STEP 3

Open a business bank account

Stripe deposits payouts here. Stripe requires a business account (not a personal one) matching the EIN. Mixing business and personal money also creates a tax mess.

> RECOMMENDED
>
> **Mercury** (mercury.com). Online-only, no monthly fees, no minimum balance, opens in ~30 minutes online after the LLC is approved. Built for small businesses that don't need to deposit cash. Integrates cleanly with Stripe.

STEP BY STEP

1. Go to `mercury.com`. Click "Open an account".
2. Sign up with your business email (recommend the same one you'll use for Stripe).
3. Upload, in order: Articles of Organization (PDF from Step 1), EIN confirmation letter (PDF from Step 2), driver's license (front + back photo), your SSN.
4. Confirm business address (can be your home address; Mercury doesn't require a separate office).
5. Submit. Approval typically takes 1–3 business days.
6. Once approved, log in and grab the **routing number** and **account number** from the dashboard. **Send to Van** (or save these for the Stripe step yourself — see Phase III).

> ALTERNATIVES
>
> **Chase Business Complete** or **Bank of America Business Advantage**. Better if you ever need to deposit cash or have a brick-and-mortar habit. Downside: $15–25/month unless you keep ~$2,000+ minimum balance.
>
> **Novo** or **Bluevine**. Other online business banks similar to Mercury. Mercury is the cleanest in our experience but any of these work.

TIME 30 min to apply, 1–3 days to approve COST Free (Mercury)

PHASE II

Email infrastructure

Pick a domain so emails come from `noreply@your-domain.com` instead of a generic sandbox address. Required for client emails (paid invoices, magic-link sign-in, donation thank-yous) to actually land in real inboxes.

ESTIMATED: 1 HOUR · CAN RUN IN PARALLEL WITH PHASE I

PHASE II · STEP 4

Choose and verify an email domain

Currently emails come from a Resend sandbox address that only delivers to your own inbox. Once a domain is verified, every prospect, client, and donor receives email from `noreply@your-domain` — lands in their inbox like any other legitimate email.

> RECOMMENDED
>
> **Use `mail.steele-co.com`** (a subdomain of your main domain). Reasoning: keeps the website's DNS (managed by Vercel) separate from email DNS, so changes to one don't risk breaking the other. Industry standard.
>
> *Prerequisite:* you (or Van) must already own `steele-co.com`. If not yet, buy it from **Cloudflare Registrar** ($9.15/year, no markup) or **Namecheap** ($11/year). Other registrars work but tend to upsell aggressively.

STEP BY STEP

1. Decide on the domain. **Send to Van** the domain you want (e.g., `mail.steele-co.com`).
2. Van will go to `resend.com/domains` and click "Add domain", then send you a list of 4 DNS records to add (an MX record and three TXT records for SPF, DKIM, and DMARC).
3. Log into your domain registrar (Cloudflare / Namecheap / wherever you bought the domain).
4. Find the DNS settings for `steele-co.com`. Add each of the 4 records Van sent. *Copy and paste exactly* — one wrong character and email won't deliver.
5. Save. DNS changes typically take 5–30 minutes to propagate, sometimes a few hours.
6. Tell Van it's done. He'll check Resend's verification screen and confirm.
7. Once verified, Van updates the production environment so all real emails (welcome, paid invoice, donation thank-you, magic link) come from your domain.

> ALTERNATIVES
>
> **Use the apex (`steele-co.com`) directly.** Works, but if you ever need to add another email provider or change MX records, you're editing the same DNS zone the website depends on. More risk for no gain.
>
> **Use a different domain entirely** (e.g., `mail.cfbcllc.com` if you don't want to involve `steele-co.com`). Works fine; just pick one and tell Van.

TIME 30 min for you, ~30 min wait for DNS COST $0 if you own the domain, ~$10/yr if buying

PHASE III

Stripe

Open the Stripe account, finish identity verification, create the products you'll sell. Required for both paying clients (subscriptions) and donations. Phase I (LLC + EIN + bank) must be complete before starting.

ESTIMATED: 1 DAY FOR SETUP, 24–48H FOR KYC APPROVAL

PHASE III · STEP 5

Create your Stripe account

Stripe is the payment processor. They handle credit cards, ACH transfers, the actual money movement. They'll verify your identity (called "KYC" — Know Your Customer) using the LLC docs and EIN you already have.

> RECOMMENDED
>
> Use the **same email address** for Stripe that you'll use for the "failed payment" alerts (see Phase IV) and the "reply-to" on thank-you emails. One inbox to monitor.

STEP BY STEP

1. Go to `dashboard.stripe.com/register`
2. Sign up with your business email and a strong password. Set up 2-factor authentication when prompted — required for an account that handles money.
3. You'll land in the test-mode dashboard. Click **"Activate your account"** in the top-right.
4. Fill the activation form:
    - Country: United States
    - Business type: **Company** → **LLC**
    - Business name: your LLC's legal name (e.g., "Steele & Co. LLC")
    - EIN: the 9-digit number from Phase I Step 2
    - Industry: "Personal Services" → "Personal training / fitness"
    - Business website: your live website URL (Van can provide if not yet known)
    - Business address: your home or registered-agent address
    - Statement descriptor: "STEELE COACHING" (or similar — this is what shows on client credit-card statements; max 22 characters)
5. Add a representative (you): name, title (Owner), DOB, SSN, home address.
6. Add bank account: routing number + account number from Mercury (Phase I Step 3).
7. Upload a photo of your driver's license.
8. Submit. Stripe usually approves in 24–48 hours. Sometimes hours.
9. While waiting, you can still build products in test mode (see Step 6). Test mode uses fake credit-card numbers and never charges real money.

0. Once approved, **tell Van**. He'll need the live API key (from Stripe dashboard → Developers → API keys → reveal) to wire production.

Keep API keys secret. Treat the live secret key like a password: don’t paste it in chat, email, or screenshots. Send it via 1Password, Bitwarden, or any password manager that supports secure sharing.

TIME 1 hour to apply, 24–48h for approval

COST Free to open. Stripe takes 2.9% + $0.30 per charge.

PHASE III · STEP 6

Create the coaching subscription product

Stripe needs to know what you sell. We create a single “Product” (Steele & Co. coaching) with one or more “Prices” (e.g., $200/month). The price ID is what the app references when it bills a client.

> RECOMMENDED
>
> **Start with one price tier: $X/month** (you decide the number). Reasoning: keeps invoicing simple, easier accounting, no decision-paralysis for prospects. You can add tiers later in 5 minutes when you have signal on what to differentiate.
>
> *Pricing thought:* for hands-on remote coaching with weekly check-ins and video review, $200–$400/month is the typical market. $200 is accessible; $300 signals premium. Pick what reflects your time investment.

STEP BY STEP

1. In the Stripe dashboard, switch to **Test mode** (toggle in top-right). We always create products in test mode first, verify everything works, then duplicate to live mode.
2. Sidebar → **Product catalog** → **+ Add product**.
3. Fill:
   - Name: “Steele & Co. Coaching”
   - Description: “Monthly powerlifting coaching subscription”
   - Image: optional, can add later
4. Under “Pricing”:
   - Pricing model: **Standard pricing**
   - Price: enter your number (e.g., 200.00)
   - Billing period: **Monthly**
   - Currency: **USD**
   - Tax behavior: leave default (we’re not collecting sales tax for V1)
5. Save the product. On the product page, find the **Price ID** (looks like `price_1Q...something`). Copy it.
6. Switch to **Live mode** (top-right toggle). Repeat steps 2–5 to create the same product in live mode. Copy that Price ID too.
7. **Send to Van** both Price IDs (test and live) and the dollar amount in cents (e.g., $200 = 20000 cents).

> ALTERNATIVE — MULTI-TIER PRICING

> Create three Prices under the same Product: Online ($X/mo), Hybrid ($Y/mo), Meet Prep ($Z one-time). More revenue flexibility but more decisions for prospects and more accounting columns. *Recommend deferring this until you have at least 5 paying clients on the simple tier.*

TIME 15 minutes COST Free

PHASE III · STEP 7

Configure the Stripe webhook (after deployment)

A “webhook” is how Stripe tells the app when a payment succeeded, failed, or a subscription was updated. The app needs to know so it can mark the client paid, send the receipt email, and update your dashboard. Set up *after* the production app is deployed.

> RECOMMENDED
>
> **Van handles this end-to-end.** You don’t need to do anything except confirm the production URL once and copy the webhook signing secret to Van.

STEP BY STEP (WHEN THE TIME COMES)

1. Van will deploy the app to the production URL (e.g., `https://steele-co.com`).
2. In Stripe dashboard → **Developers** → **Webhooks** → **+ Add endpoint**.
3. Endpoint URL: `https://<your-live-domain>/api/webhooks/stripe`
4. Listen to the following events (Van will provide a list to copy/paste): `invoice.paid`, `invoice.payment_failed`, `customer.subscription.created`, `customer.subscription.updated`, `customer.subscription.deleted`, `customer.created`, `checkout.session.completed`, `charge.refunded`.
5. Click **Add endpoint**. On the resulting page, click **Reveal signing secret** — starts with `whsec_`.
6. **Send to Van** the signing secret. He’ll set it as the `STRIPE_WEBHOOK_SECRET` environment variable on the production server.
7. Van triggers a smoke test (creates a test customer, runs the test card `4242 4242 4242 4242`) to confirm webhooks are flowing.

TIME 10 minutes (when triggered) COST Free

PHASE IV

Pricing & product decisions

Quick decisions that shape what the app shows and sends. None of these block Phases I–III — you can answer them anytime, and changing your mind later is easy.

ESTIMATED: 30 MINUTES TOTAL

PHASE IV · STEP 8

Confirm coaching subscription pricing

The number you'll charge clients per month. Already covered in Step 6 if you set the Stripe Price — this is just for explicit decision-tracking.

> RECOMMENDED
>
> **$250/month** as a starting tier. Reasoning: positions you above template-only services ($50–100), below national-team coaches ($500+), and matches your hands-on-with-video-review value. Adjust up after the first few clients are signed if demand is strong.

STEP BY STEP

1. Decide on the monthly amount.
2. If different from the Step 6 product, update the Stripe Price (in test mode, then live).
3. **Send to Van**: the final number. He puts it in the app's seed script.

PHASE IV · STEP 9

Confirm suggested donation amounts

The donation page (`/team/donate`) shows three preset amount buttons plus a custom field. Three numbers nudge donors toward the right ballpark.

> RECOMMENDED
>
> **$25 / $50 / $100**, with a custom field for any other amount. Standard for grassroots youth-team fundraising. $25 is accessible to most casual supporters; $100 lets bigger donors land naturally without typing; the custom field accommodates a $1,000 grand-uncle.

STEP BY STEP

1. Decide the three amounts.
2. **Send to Van** the three numbers.

> ALTERNATIVES
>
> **$50 / $100 / $250.** If your donor base is wealthier (parents of athletes who travel to Nationals tend to skew higher).
>
> **Just a custom field, no presets.** Removes anchor effect. Tends to lower average donation. Not recommended.

PHASE IV · STEP 10

Decide who gets failed-payment alerts

When a client's monthly subscription card declines, the app sends an internal alert to a specified email so you can reach out to the client. (Stripe also emails the client directly via its own dunning system — you don't need to handle that.)

> RECOMMENDED
>
> **Your personal email** (the one you check first thing each morning). Reasoning: V1 is single-coach, you handle every client conversation, no need to introduce a shared inbox. Keep it simple.

STEP BY STEP

1. Pick the email address.
2. **Send to Van** — he sets it as the `FAILED_PAYMENT_ALERT_EMAIL` environment variable.

> ALTERNATIVE
>
> **A shared inbox** like `coach@steele-co.com` if you ever bring on an assistant or want Van to also see failures. Easy to switch later.

PHASE IV · STEP 11

Confirm thank-you email signoff & reply-to

Donation thank-you emails get sent automatically. They need a signoff (“William Steele, Head Coach”) and a reply-to address so a donor who hits Reply gets to the right person.

RECOMMENDED

Signoff: “William Steele — Head Coach, Steele & Co.”
Reply-to: `william@steele-co.com` (or whichever email you check most).

STEP BY STEP

1. Decide the signoff line and reply-to address.
2. **Send to Van.**

PHASE IV · STEP 12

Review the About-page copy

Your `/about` page already has draft copy. Read it, edit if needed. Prospective athletes will read this before applying.

> RECOMMENDED
>
> **2–3 paragraphs, concrete and specific.** Federations you've coached in, athletes you've worked with at meets, what makes your approach distinct. Avoid generic credentials and motivational language — serious lifters smell it immediately.

STEP BY STEP

1. Visit the live site's `/about` page (Van will share the URL once production is up).
2. Read end-to-end. Does it sound like you? Are the facts right?
3. If you want changes, just send Van the rewritten copy. Easier than doing track-changes.
4. Optional: provide a 1:1 photo (square crop, head-and-shoulders, decent light). Doesn't need to be professional — iPhone selfie in good window light is fine.

PHASE V

Legal documents

Privacy policy, terms of service, refund policy. Required by Stripe (they'll ask during account activation if not already on the site) and protect you legally. The app has placeholder routes ready — just need the actual text.

ESTIMATED: 1 HOUR

PHASE V · STEP 13

Generate privacy + terms + refund policy

These are standard legal docs. You don't need a lawyer for V1 — a generator produces the right text for 95% of small-business cases.

> RECOMMENDED
>
> **Termly (free generator)** at `termly.io`. Each policy takes ~10 minutes via a guided questionnaire. Output is plain HTML you can paste into the app. Good enough for V1; upgrade to a lawyer-reviewed version once revenue justifies it.

STEP BY STEP

1. Go to `termly.io`. Create a free account.
2. Generate **Privacy Policy**:
   - Business type: LLC
   - Do you collect emails? Yes
   - Do you process payments? Yes, via Stripe
   - Do you use cookies? Yes (for sign-in sessions)
   - Do you have a newsletter? Yes

   Copy the generated text.
3. Generate **Terms of Service** with the same questionnaire flow.
4. Generate **Refund Policy**. Recommended language: "Coaching subscriptions are non-refundable for the current billing period. You may cancel future renewals at any time. Donations are non-refundable."
5. **Send to Van** all three documents. He'll wire them into the existing `/privacy`, `/terms`, `/refund-policy` routes the app already reserves.

> ALTERNATIVES
>
> **lubenda** (~$30 one-time setup, ~$30/year). More polished output, supports auto-updates if laws change. Worth it once you have a few paying clients.
>
> **Hire a lawyer.** $500–1,500. Overkill for a single-coach SaaS. Revisit when revenue passes ~$10k/month.

TIME 1 hour COST Free (Termly)

PHASE VI

Ongoing operations

Things you'll do regularly after launch. Not blockers — included so you know what to expect once paying clients and donors start arriving.

ESTIMATED: ~1 HOUR/MONTH AFTER FIRST DONATIONS

PHASE VI · STEP 14

Send the monthly donor newsletter

Every donor is automatically added to a newsletter list (with one-click unsubscribe). You commit to a monthly update to keep them engaged. V1 is manual: Van exports the list, you write and send.

> RECOMMENDED
>
> **Substack** (substack.com). Free, lets donors read the update without an account, has a clean reader experience. Set up a free publication called “Steele & Co. Team Updates”. Import the donor CSV the first time, then just write each month.

STEP BY STEP

1. Sign up for Substack at `substack.com`. Pick a publication name.
2. Wait until your first donation arrives (or skip until then).
3. In the app: go to `/coach/donations`. Click “Export newsletter list (CSV)”.
4. In Substack: Settings → Subscribers → Import. Upload the CSV.
5. Write a 3-paragraph update: what the team is training, who has a meet coming up, a thank-you. End with one specific name to avoid sounding generic.
6. Send. Substack handles delivery, unsubscribes, archive page.
7. Repeat monthly. The app keeps adding new donors to subsequent CSVs — you re-import the delta each time. (Eventually we’ll automate this.)

> ALTERNATIVES
>
> **Mailchimp** (free tier up to 500 contacts). More design control, more polished. Worth it if you want a branded look matching your website.
>
> **BCC from Gmail.** Free, zero setup, but unsubscribes don’t auto-process, and you’re responsible for CAN-SPAM compliance. Only acceptable for <25 donors.
>
> **Skip the newsletter entirely.** Don’t do this. Donors opted in expecting updates — ghosting them poisons the well for future donations.

TIME 1 hour first time, 30 min thereafter COST Free

PHASE VI · STEP 15

Coach athletes through public profiles

Each athlete on your roster can publish a public profile at `/team/<name>`. These are recruitment surfaces — prospective clients see real athletes, not stock photos. You approve each one before it goes live.

> RECOMMENDED
>
> **Onboarding script:** when you take on a new athlete, send this in your welcome message: “Once you’re signed in, click ‘Profile’ in the top nav and fill in your headline, bio, and meet results. I’ll review and publish to the team page.” Then approve within 24 hours so they feel seen.

STEP BY STEP

1. Athlete signs in to the app, clicks **Profile** in top nav, fills the form (headline, bio, optional photo URL, optional recent meet results), saves.
2. App shows the athlete: “Pending coach approval. Slug will be /team/*their-name* once published.”
3. You sign in to coach side, go to **Athletes** → click the athlete — you’ll see a “Public profile” section showing their bio preview.
4. Read the bio. If it’s good, click **Approve & publish**. The profile goes live at `/team/<slug>` within seconds.
5. If you want changes first, message the athlete directly — they can edit and you re-approve.
6. If something goes wrong later (athlete gets dropped, says something off-color), click **Unpublish** on that same page. Returns the profile to draft state.

TIME ~10 min per athlete onboarded COST Free

APPENDIX A

Master “send to Van” checklist

Everything Van needs from you to wire production. Pin this list. Cross items off as you finish them.

- ☐ **LLC name + Articles of Organization PDF** (Phase I Step 1)
- ☐ **EIN (9-digit) + IRS confirmation letter PDF** (Phase I Step 2)
- ☐ **Mercury account routing + account number** (Phase I Step 3)
- ☐ **Email domain choice** (Phase II Step 4)
- ☐ **Confirmation that DNS records are added** (Phase II Step 4)
- ☐ **Stripe live API key** (Phase III Step 5; via password manager)
- ☐ **Stripe Price IDs** — both test and live (Phase III Step 6)
- ☐ **Stripe webhook signing secret** (Phase III Step 7; via password manager)
- ☐ **Coaching subscription monthly amount** (Phase IV Step 8)
- ☐ **Donation preset amounts** (Phase IV Step 9)
- ☐ **Failed-payment alert email** (Phase IV Step 10)
- ☐ **Thank-you email signoff & reply-to address** (Phase IV Step 11)
- ☐ **About-page edits + optional photo** (Phase IV Step 12)
- ☐ **Privacy + Terms + Refund policy text** (Phase V Step 13)

APPENDIX B

Glossary

Terms that appear above, in plain English.

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS
LLC	Limited Liability Company. A business entity that protects your personal assets if the business is sued.
EIN	Employer Identification Number. The IRS's federal tax ID for your business. 9 digits.
KYC	Know Your Customer. The identity-verification process Stripe runs before approving an account.
API key	A long secret string that lets the app talk to Stripe on your behalf. Treat like a password.
Webhook	A URL Stripe pings when an event happens (payment succeeded, etc.) so the app can react.
Webhook secret	A separate password that lets the app verify the webhook came from Stripe and not a forger.
DNS	Domain Name System. The phone book of the internet. You add records here to prove a domain is yours.
MX record	A DNS entry that says "email for this domain goes to these servers".
SPF / DKIM / DMARC	Three DNS records that prove your email is legitimately from your domain. Without them, Gmail and Outlook send you to spam.
Stripe Customer	A record of one of your clients in Stripe's system. Holds their payment method and subscription history.
Stripe Subscription	The recurring billing arrangement: customer + price + status (active / past_due / canceled).
Stripe Checkout	The hosted payment page where the client enters their card. Stripe-branded, secure, no work for us.
Stripe Customer Portal	The hosted page where a client can update their card, view invoices, cancel. Stripe-branded.
Resend	The email service the app uses to send transactional emails (welcomes, receipts, thank-yous).
MRR	Monthly Recurring Revenue. Sum of all active subscription amounts. Shown on your dashboard.

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS
Past due	A subscription whose last invoice failed to charge. Stripe retries automatically over a few days.
Test mode vs live mode	Stripe has two parallel universes: test mode uses fake cards and never moves real money; live mode is real. Always build in test first.

APPENDIX C

Suggested timeline

A two-week launch path assuming you start today. Adjust to your own pace — nothing is on fire, but momentum compounds.

DAY	WHAT YOU DO
Day 1 (today)	File LLC online (Phase I Step 1). Pick name, pay fee, submit. Buy `steele-co.com` if not yet owned (Phase II Step 4 prerequisite).
Day 2	Send Van the email-domain choice (Phase II Step 4). He sets up Resend; you add DNS records once he sends them.
Day 3–14	Wait for LLC approval (state-dependent).
Day after LLC approves	Get EIN online (Phase I Step 2 — 30 min). Open Mercury account (Phase I Step 3 — 30 min).
Day after Mercury approves (~2 days later)	Open Stripe account, submit KYC (Phase III Step 5 — 1 hour).
Day after Stripe approves (~24–48h later)	Create Stripe products in test + live mode (Phase III Step 6 — 15 min). Send Price IDs to Van.
Anytime in between	Generate legal docs (Phase V Step 13 — 1 hour). Confirm pricing, donation amounts, alert emails (Phase IV — 30 min). Review the About page (Phase IV Step 12 — 30 min).
Final day	Van deploys to production. You configure the Stripe webhook (Phase III Step 7 — 10 min). Smoke test together. Launch.

Realistic launch range: 2–3 weeks from today. The slow part is waiting for the LLC state filing (1–3 weeks) and Stripe KYC (24–48h). Everything else is hours.